“Why are there no stories of the children of the Watchers?” The question left Sylva before she had a chance to even think about it. The Prophet paused, looking at Sylva with a slightly bemused expression. Sylva blushed but continued onwards. “There are countless stories of the children of Prophets! By the Queen of the Waters herself, my Spirit-Mother’s Spirit-Father was a Prophet!”.

“Why do you think this is the case?” Sylva sighed, reaching for one of the berries sitting in the bowl. The teardrop shaped fruit tasted rather sweet, seeming to have far more juice stored within than a berry of its size should contain. *Hurst will be glad there was enough to have spares.* Sylva heard The Prophet clear her throat. Sylva looked up, seeing The Prophet staring at her expectantly, her earlier amusement fading away. “You have yet to answer my question, dear Sylva.” Sylva thought for a moment, letting her memories of the tales of past Watchers flow through her brain.

“Is it because they’re usually separate from the rest of Mistgrove?” Sylva eventually asked. The Prophet stared at her, then sat up. The room they were in was located in the ruins at the center of Mistgrove. The ruins themselves had few private areas, with entrance to any strictly forbidden unless you were accompanied by The Prophet or The Watcher. Even in this relatively private room, the walls had several holes. Sunlight streamed through in separate beams, lighting up the room in a patchwork fashion. Sylva and The Prophet were seated at a large stone that had been roughly scraped into a workable table, in the part of the room that had the most regular light. Several stones had been rolled into the room to function as chairs around the table.

The Prophet sat at the chair next to Sylva, keeping her gaze locked onto Sylva’s. Sylva felt uncomfortable. The Prophet was one of the only people who knew more about the secrets of Mistgrove than Sylva. One of the only people the spirits told their secrets. Some of those secrets were unknown to even the Watcher. “Is it because they aren’t permitted to join a family? No, that can’t be it. If Prophets can have children, then of course the Watchers can as well…” Sylva pondered her question further. She saw The Prophet had kept watching her. She noticed several of the spirits around them had come to rest, as if drawn in by this conversation.

“May I ask the reason you ask me this?” Sylva paused. She hadn’t expected that question. She looked back at The Prophet, realizing the emotion in her eyes. *She’s forlorn. She’s not disappointed at me for interrupting the lesson. It looks like… it looks like she’s been forced to reveal a secret she wished to keep hidden forever*. “Is it Hurst?” Sylva felt her face redden. Several of the spirits around her started to swirl excitedly. She even heard the chatter of some of the spirits of love drifting on the winds towards them.

“He is part of it. But this is a question I have had ever since I learned about my family. Why are there only the descendants of Prophets? Why do the Watcher’s never leave any behind?” The Prophet laid her hand on Sylvas’s shoulder. She seemed to weigh something and then spoke.

“How many tales of the Watchers involve them reaching old age? How many of them tell tale of a Watcher deciding they’ve given enough? How many have felt that they’ve earned their twilight before they go to live with the gods? I know of several Prophets who have done so. I plan to do so myself on your twentieth year.” Sylva looked up shocked. *Her twentieth year? That was only 2 years away!* “The

answer is none of them. Not a single one has done so. Do you know why that is?" Sylva shook her head. Her mind was racing. She could've sworn at least **one** of the Watchers had retired, hadn't they? "It is for one simple reason, my dear Sylva. Do you know when a Watcher knows they're going to die?" Sylva shook her head. The Prophet looked at her and then spoke.

"You and that Prophet girl is quite close, aren't ye? Ye' plan on starting a family with her? Bring in a couple of ye' other friends?" Hurst looked up at The Watcher, her cloak billowing around her. It was made of material one couldn't even imagine describing. Supposedly it was a gift from the first ever Watcher, carved from the hide of the demon that destroyed the ancient city. The demon that came from the portal of destruction.

"Why do you ask such things of me?" Hurst opened his pouch, placing the berries into it. He closed it and stood up, turning to look at The Watcher. The expression on her scar covered face was amusement. "Do you find enjoyment in trying to embarrass me? I cannot deceive you. I have thought on such things." The Watcher started to laugh, leaning forward on her walking stick to keep balance.

"'I have thought on such things.' He says!" Her laughter caused her to lose balance, and she tumbled to the ground. Hurst leapt towards her, holding his hand out to catch her. *By the spirits of the-* Hurst thought before he realized what this was. She snapped her hand onto his wrist, pulling him towards her. Hurst rolled into it, using his greater size and weight to slam his shoulder into her stomach. He felt her roll onto his back, wrapping her arm around his neck. He frantically tried to throw her off of him, but she had him. He released his knees, falling backward to slam her into the ground. He rolled over onto his knees, prepared to lunge at her, but she was gone. He spun around, searching for her. *This is a test. Where would she be…* A thought hit Hurst, just a second too late. He spun towards the cluster of spirits that had been drawn to them. Right as he did, The Watcher lunged through them at him, wrapping her arm around his neck again, pulling him to the ground with her momentum. He struggled in vain for a couple of moments, before slapping her on the back.

"Even with one arm ye' still can't keep up with me." The Watcher was chuckling, releasing Hurst from her powerful grip. Hurst stood up, then reached his hand out to help her up. She took his hand, then immediately spun on the ground, trying to sweep his legs out. Hurst was ready for her this time and used her spin to flip her on her stomach. He kneeled on her back, holding his hand against the back of her head.

"You forget I have learned your tricks. You cannot always fool me the same ways, Master." Hurst stood up, walking back to where his pouch had fallen in the tumble. The spirits around him swirled, chattering away. "It was a friendly battle. No one is fighting. We are friends. I promise." The spirits calmed down, floating away towards the deep woods. "Was your question genuine? Or was this merely another test of my skill?"

"Both." Hurst sighed. He kept an eye on The Watcher as he picked up her staff and threw it at her. She caught it in her left hand, the movement revealing the open air beneath the cloak where her right arm should've been. Hurst felt a stab of pain at seeing that. He should've been able to help. He shouldn't have left her alone. "Ye' had the kid with ye' Hurst. You couldn't have done anything about it." Hurst

looked back at The Watcher. She had the same look in her eye that she had whenever she caught Hurst looking at her missing arm. Hurst nodded, turning back towards the location of Mistgrove.

"Are The Watchers banned from such things, Master?" Hurst had been wanting to ask this question for years. He turned towards her. "Is that why none of us have left behind any children?" The Watcher looked around her, noticing a log a few feet away from her. She walked over to take a seat and gestured for Hurst to sit on the ground in front of her. Hurst walked over, sitting cross-legged in front of The Watcher. She seemed to search for the words to say. He and his master were quite similar. They weren't gifted in the way of words like The Prophet or Sylva were. They didn't know how to cloak sharp words in kindness like his Spirit-Mother. They were like his Sight-Father. Direct.

"We aren't banned from such things, as ye' say." Hurst looked up at his master. She seemed to be debating if she should continue, before deciding to power onwards. "We can join families. We can have children. There are no rules against it." Hurst waited. There was something she was going to tell him. "You know the kind of things we see Hurst. The others don't understand, ye know? Not even the Prophets truly understand how it feels to see a demon. Most of 'em only see a demon once or twice while training with the Watcher." Hurst nodded. This made sense. His teacher sighed and looked at him. "That's the story me Master told me. That's the story I should be telling ye'. But there's a different reason. We're called The Watcher. We Watch. We protect Mistgrove from the kind of spookies that the regular people can't understand." His teacher scratched her head again, looking like she would rather be anywhere else. "A more accurate name would be 'The Wall.' Or maybe even 'The Sacrifice'".

Hurst was confused. "What do you mean? Is our job not to Watch? To protect?" His master didn't answer. She was staring off at the forest behind him. Hurst looked around to see what had caught The Watchers eye, when he noticed the spirits all around them had fled. Hurst knew what this meant. He leapt to his feet, spinning around so he landed between The Watcher and whatever was behind them. Hurst looked deep into the forest. He couldn't quite make out what had caught his master's eye, not until he heard a voice he had desperately tried to forget.

"***Oh? The little squeak?..... I haven't seen you in…. well, time doesn't matter to us…***" With every word, the forest around them grew darker and darker. Hurst stared into the darkest section of the woods, one that seemed to be growing larger and larger, before a demon with 6 legs crawled out. It was canine like, with massive glowing teeth and eyes filled with pure malice. Hurst was taken back to his childhood. Sylva screaming. A monster. A voice that filled him with fear. Learning he could hear the spirits. The day he met The Watcher.

Hurst felt a hand lay on his shoulder. He looked behind him to see The Watcher looking at the demon. He felt her hand grip his shoulder. He looked back towards the demon and then heard a rustling sound. Something was placed onto his shoulders. *What the...* Hurst felt at it. It felt strange to the touch, some kind of fur but of a creature that Hurst couldn't even imagine. *Oh spirits.* ***It was the Watcher's Cloak***. Hurst looked at The Watcher, seeing that she was pointing to something huddling in the woods behind the demon. It was a child.

"I'll draw the demon away. Ye' save the child. That way, you two might have a chance." Hurst spun to his master. He wanted to object. He wanted to tell her they could fight it together. He wanted to

be able to look the demon in the eye as it was destroyed. But he knew. He knew that he wasn't strong enough. Maybe if The Watcher still had both of her arms. Maybe if Hurst had been just a little stronger, they could've taken it together. "If you make it back to Mistgrove, wait with the Prophets. The spirits will find you if I-" His master couldn't finish. Hurst nodded and turned to face her one last time. He wanted to burn her face into his mind. He wanted to make sure he never forgot it. She smiled at him and ruffled his hair. "Ye' grew up a lot from when I first met ye'. Sorry I couldn't teach ye' everything I wanted to. I'm proud of ye'."

With that, she bolted towards the demon, shouting in the language of the gods. The creature reared back and ran towards her. About halfway towards the demon, she started hurling insults towards it. It roared in anger and ran towards her even faster. With one last look back at Hurst, she started running away from Mistgrove. Hurst saw dozens of spirits trailing after her. Some of them were Zephyr spirits. Maybe she'd have a chance. Maybe she'd make it.

Hurst ran towards the child. They were in the deep woods but were just on the edge. Mistgrove was only a few hours' walk away. He knew children would dare their friends to go into the deep woods. It was a way for them to show off that they weren't scared of the monsters within. This child had drawn the demon. There were scrapes and cuts up and down his arms. He was frozen in fear. Hurst crouched down, talking to him quickly. "Child of Mistgrove, did any come with you? Were you alone?" The child looked at him. He couldn't even speak due to the fear. Hurst placed a hand over the child's eyes. In the language of the gods, he spoke. "Oh, great gods of the forest, I beg of you to bless this child's mind." Hurst had seen spirits of joy when he and his master were speaking, so if he was lucky….

The child's eyes widened, and he turned towards Hurst. He started chattering at a speed Hurst couldn't understand. Hurst placed his hands on the boy's mouth. *Spirits, this boy can't be more than 5. My hand nearly covers his entire face!* "Were you alone?"

"My big sister was with me. The monster got her." Hurst cursed under his breath. He nodded and leaned down to pick up the child.

"My Master will avenge your sister. For now, we must get you home safely." The kid shook his head, pulling away from Hurst. He pointed to the shadows behind Hurst.

"Not the big monster. *That* monster." Hurst spun around to see a smaller demon lunge at him. This one wasn't canine, more humanoid. It was carrying something in what seemed to be it's left hand.

"A rope?" Hurst said, rapidly moving around to stay out of the reach of the demon. "It has a rope?" Hurst shouldn't have been surprised by this. The creatures of the deep woods often defied logic. Why should one carrying a rope confuse him so much. Hurst dove under the demons' lunge, slamming into its legs. He spun it around, putting it into a similar hold that he put his master into earlier. He then leaned down and whispered into what appeared to be a strangely deformed ear. "I will speak once, and only once. This child is not yours to claim. None of those here are yours to claim. Begone or be destroyed." The demon trashed even harder. "I see you have made your choice." Hurst placed a hand on the back of the demons' head, praying to the gods in their speech. A flash of light blinded Hurst for a moment. Once he could see again, the demon was gone.

He looked towards the child. The child appeared to be fine. Hurst looked back at where the demon was, only to see a dark orb in its place. Hurst picked up the orb and placed it into his pouch. He walked over to the child and picked him up. “Now we can be on our way home. Does that sound fun to you?”

“What about my sister? Did you find her?” Hurst paused. He was confused. Didn’t the child say the demon got her? *The demon had a rope.* Hurst looked around him. The child started calling out. “Aera? Aera? Where are you?” Hurst tried to shush the child. He had no idea if there were any more demons within this area, but shouting was a surefire way to draw them. Hurst heard rustling behind him, and to see tied up young woman had dragged her way towards them. She was trying to call out, but the rope was covering her mouth as well. Hurst quickly removed the rope, and the girl stood up. She appeared to be around Hurst’s age.

“You saved us.” The girl seemed to be quite shaken up but was clearly trying to appear strong for her younger brother.

“I was merely fulfilling my duty as The Watcher. Do you know the way back to Mistgrove?” The girl nodded. Hurst breathed a sigh of relief. “In that case, I must ask a favor of you. I should accompany you home, but I must see to my master. We are at the very edge of the deep forest. Once you cross the edge, nothing should bring danger to you. Can you make your way home?” The girl nodded again. Hurst got to a knee, tapping his forehead against her and her brother’s knuckles, a sign of deep respect. “ I shall find you two in Mistgrove as soon as I return, to ensure you arrived home safely. I promise.” The girl and her brother nodded and walked towards Mistgrove. Hurst turned back towards the direction his master had gone. “I am sorry for disobeying. I cannot merely abandon you.” Hurst spoke with the spirits to be given the sight to see the location of his master. “I shall be there to help you soon.” Hurst set off on his walk.

Sylva sat back down. She felt panic rising in her chest. One of the town farmers had just walked in asking about their children. The children had been playing in the woods and hadn’t returned for a few hours. Sylva had intended to ask the spirits to find Hurst or The Watcher, but the children had emerged from the woods. They told a story of a demon that sounded far too familiar to Sylva for her own comfort, and that they had been saved by Hurst and The Watcher. Hurst has apparently left to find his master, leaving Sylva to stew in her terror. The Prophet had been called to her other duties. So, all Sylva could do was wait. Wait she did.

Three days later, Sylva was sitting in the room she had asked the prophet about the Watchers’ children in. Hurst hadn’t come back yet. It was now dark. Sylva should really sleep for the night, but she felt too much dread. It wasn’t like Hurst and The Watcher would check in with them regularly, but after what she learned from The Prophet, she could only feel dread. She noticed the spirits were swirling around her, her nervousness clearly affecting them.

The door swung open. A figure in a dark cloak stood in the doorway. There was a strange bulge under its arm, pushing the cloak out in front of it. Sylva looked towards the figures’ eyes and felt her tension melt

away. Hurst staggered into the room, falling down onto the nearest chair. He let out a deep sigh before looking at her with a rough smile. “Hello Sylva.”

Sylva walked over and sat down next to Hurst. He had his eyes closed while looking up towards the ceiling. He was covered in sweat and dirt. There were leaves stuck in his hair and a few new cuts on his neck and hands. The spirits around him were slowing down, letting Sylva determine what they were *Sorrow. Grief. Rage. Anger. Guilt. Exhaustion. Agony. Something happened in those woods.* Sylva thought to herself. She put her hand on Hurst’s shoulder, causing him to open his eyes and look at her. The spirits around him slowed even more, seeming to be waiting to see what Sylva would say.

“The children made it home. They’re safe.” Hurst let out a deep breath. He placed a hand on hers. He sat there for a few minutes, seeming to be letting himself relax and think about whatever happened to him. Sylva wanted to ask him about what happened. She wanted to ask if The Watcher was dead. She wanted to ask where Hurst had gone. “You’re wearing the cloak.” It slipped out of her mouth before she could stop herself.

“I am.” Hurst seemed to accept something when he said that. He leaned forward, putting his head in between his knees, his hands clasped over the back of his neck. “I am…The Watcher.” Sylva felt dread seep into her chest and spread throughout her entire body. This meant…

“Did you see it happen?” Hurst nodded. Hurst reached into his cloak, pulling out the remaining pieces of the old Watchers staff. It was covered in blood and dark fur that bore resemblance to the cloak Hurst wore. “Hurst….”

Hurst shook his head. He looked towards the door, clearly pondering something. Hurst turned to look at Sylva. “The Watchers are meant to be the wall between you and the darkness. Between Mistgrove and the demons. We… are not meant to have a happy end.” Sylva felt her question from earlier coming back to haunt her. *Why don’t the Watcher’s have descendants?* ***Because they all die too soon.*** She looked up to see Hurst had stood back up and was walking toward the door.

“What do you intend to do now?” Hurst stopped and looked at her.

“I intend to do my duty. Someone must protect the town. Someone must keep the children safe. We cannot have what happened to you and me as children happen again.” The Watcher nodded to Sylva and walked out the door.